

holder of the post was supposed to be celibate) or that his religious works were interspersed with secular madrigals. However, after Julius's death in 1555 and the brief reign of Pope Marcellus II—to whom Palestrina dedicated his most famous Mass, *Missa Papae Marcelli*—the more austere Paul IV was installed in the Vatican. The new pope dismissed Palestrina.

Nevertheless, the composer's talent and reputation ensured him work at other Roman churches. By the time he was reinstated as papal choirmaster in 1571, he had adapted his style to the demands of the Counter-Reformation (see [box](#)), describing his new works as “music written ... in accordance with the views of the most serious and religious-minded persons in high places.”

In the 1570s, plague raged in Rome. Palestrina suffered the deaths of his wife and two of his three sons. In 1581, however, he married a second time, the widow of a Roman fur trader, and took over running her former husband's business, which he handled very profitably. Alongside this commercial activity he continued to write a stream of Masses and other sacred music, including settings of the Song of Solomon published in 1584 and the *Stabat Mater* for eight voices, dating from around 1590. By the time of his death in 1594, his total output amounted to 105 Masses, more than 300 motets, and hundreds of other works, both religious and secular.